
2. City Introductions

A short historical and cultural introduction to each city in the Place column

Kolkata

Kolkata served as the capital of British India for over a century and remains India's capital of literature, adda and sweets. Its Victoria Memorial, Howrah Bridge, trams and College Street make it one of the country's most layered cities.

New Delhi

The capital was built in the early twentieth century by Lutyens and Baker, beside the older Delhi of Mughal quarters. Its wide avenues and colonial-era government buildings sit alongside forts and tombs from many eras.

Kota

Tradition says Prince Jait Singh of Bundi laid the foundations of Kota's palace in 1264. The kingdom became effectively independent in 1624 under Rao Madho Singh, with Mughal confirmation in 1631, and its rulers held the throne until the merger with India in 1948. Kota is known for Kota Doria sarees and a school of miniature painting that flowered in the 17th and 18th centuries, and today for its coaching institutes.

Rawatbhata

This small town in Chittorgarh district sits among two very different kinds of heritage. The Baroli temples lie within the Rawatbhata tehsil, and the town is also home to the Rajasthan Atomic Power Station.

Gandhisagar

The town takes its name from the dam. The Gandhi Sagar Dam is in Mandsaur district, Madhya Pradesh, on the Chambal. The reservoir and wildlife sanctuary make it a nature stop rather than a historic city.

Chandwasa

A village in Mandsaur district. The Dhamnar Buddhist and Hindu monuments lie to its east, about 75 km northeast of Mandsaur city. The monuments are often called Dhamnar, but they belong to Chandwasa.

Bhanpura

The town is home to the Daraki-Chattan rock art region, among the world's oldest, and to Hinglajgarh Fort. It also has a museum of Mandsaur's art, and it became the place where a great Maratha ruler, Yashwant Rao Holkar, died in 1811.

Kakuni

A small place in Baran district, Rajasthan. Its group of temples is listed as a state-protected monument.

Jhalwarpatan (Jhalrapatan)

The old Chandravati is a temple town. Its Chandrabhaga complex on the river bank has five temples, with the Shiva temple Sitalleshwar the most prominent. Nearby are an 11th-century Sun Temple, a Jain temple of the same period, and Gagron Fort, a UNESCO-listed fort surrounded by water.